

Nicole Kidman starring as Lucille Ball will remind a certain generation of the days when the American comedienne was a regular on Doordarshan

FILMS

HOME IS WHERE THE SET IS

Aaron Sorkin's Golden Globe-winning *Being the Ricardos* gives us an insightful behind-the-scenes peek at the personal and political dynamics behind a legendary TV show of the 1950s

I Love Lucy was America's most watched show during the 1950s. It revolved around the antics of housewife Lucy Ricardo (Lucille Ball) and her musician husband Ricky (Desi Arnaz; her husband in real life): Lucy constantly tried to escape being a housewife and become famous, get herself in trouble, and Ricky would bail her out. Lucille Ball is still regarded as America's greatest physical comedienne, and Desi Arnaz permanently changed the way sitcoms were produced with a live studio audience as the laugh track, the three-camera studio-based production model, and clever product placement. 'Honey, I'm home' was invented here. To have a Cuban front-runner in a family comedy was a first, as was the use of Ball's actual pregnancy as a trope on television. In the 1980s, watching Lucille Ball in *Here's Lucy* on Doordarshan was quite a treat.

Aaron Sorkin, the creator of *The West Wing*, *Newsroom* and *Social Network* focuses his film *Being the Ricardos* (streaming on Amazon Prime Video) on a crucial week in the life of Ball and Arnaz (Nicole Kidman and Javier Bardem)—when they fight Philip Morris for the pregnancy episodes, when communism accusations against Ball were dealt with on live TV, and when papers ran photos of Arnaz womanising.

Sorkin says in an interview that *I Love Lucy* won't be funny today—Lucy's childish incompetence, Arnaz hamming up Latin stereotypes, his rational patriarch, are hard to digest. But Sorkin captures the place the physical comedy comes from—it is precisely because Lucy embodies at every juncture the pressures of gender and the ideal of the American home that there are infinite permutations of tiny failure. The home always won, and domestic conflicts were resolved. To contrast Lucille in real life, Sorkin holds up a black mirror. We see a whip-smart, ratings-savvy Lucille who shapes the writing, who pulled Desi, who signed the autographs before he did, and who got him the role of Ricky Ricardo. But it is also a Lucille who constantly aspires for a home—after work, Arnaz plays cards and seeks the company of other women. The fantasy of domestic contentment thus completes the mirror: while Lucille has agency, Lucy has a home and they both want the other. This may explain why Ball divorced Arnaz once the show ended.

Perhaps out of a sense of justice, the film denies Arnaz a perspective. You see Bardem through Kidman's eyes—irresistible, larger than life. You are in her head when she processes how a scene will play out while it is being written (just these sequences were enough for the Golden Globe win). Despite their conflicts on set, the cast and crew lavish her with support. This, we know, is what Sorkin does best—a central figure with moral authority, and a sense of community around her. For a little while, we too bask in Lucy/ Lucille's story, with the very best of company. ■

–Suryapratim Roy